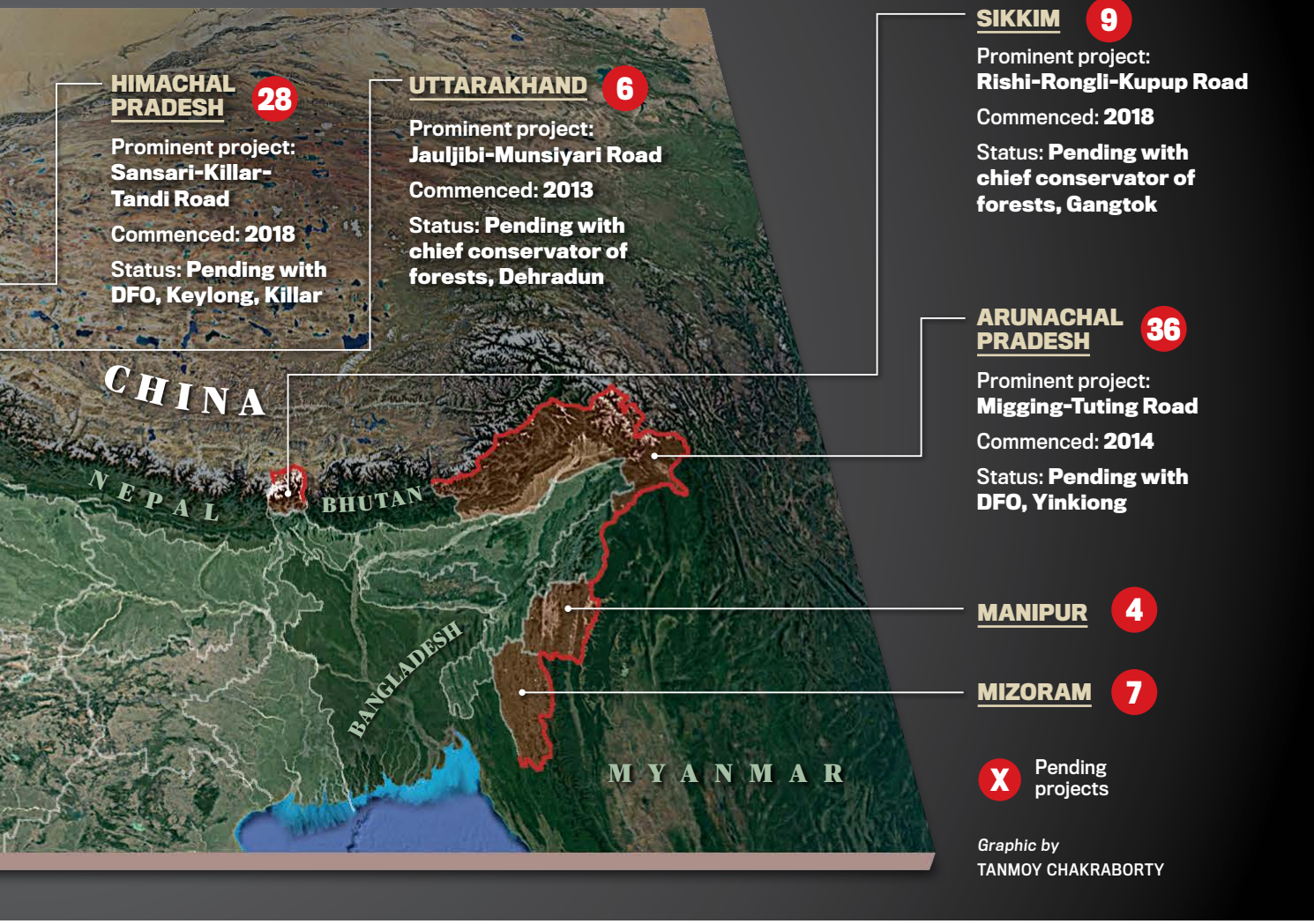


The aggressive advance of the Chinese People's Liberation Army (PLA) on vital portions of the 3,488-km-long Line of Actual Control (LAC) in recent years had sharpened fears around an old truth. Beijing had always been known to show a beaver-like diligence in building a modern road network on its side of the de facto border. Now, the clashes along the LAC in 2020 and the protracted standoff thereafter made apparent the sheer depth of its capacity build-up—new frontier depots and barracks had sprouted on the back of a massively scaled-up grid of roads and runways. That realisation acted like a spur in the flank of the Indian army, and it consequently began looking with renewed urgency at the task of ramping up its own border infrastructure.

Enhanced frontier connectivity is a military imperative for India—the terrain on this side of the LAC is vastly more perilous, and quick mobilisation of troops was clearly a stark need yet to be fully met. From roads, bridges and ammunition depots to surveillance apparatus, India has accelerated work on the nuts and bolts. From 2008 to 2014, some 7,270 metres of bridges and 3,610 km of border roads had been built. Such activity quickened under the NDA government—between 2014-20, about 14,450 metres of bridges and 4,764 km of roads were completed. The capital outlay for the Border Roads Organisation (BRO) too was increased to Rs 5,000 crore in the Union budget for 2023-24, from Rs 3,500 crore in 2022-23. And an impetus is being given to the India-China Border Roads (ICBR) project that envisages constructing strategic roads, including bridges and tunnels.

But India faces another challenge here: most frontier areas also lie in ecologically sensitive zones, and ramping up infrastructure is not a process free of doubt or logistical tangles. The Forest (Conservation) Amendment Bill 2023, which the Union government tabled on March 29, is meant to clear some of the bureaucratic jungle. Among other things, it aims to fast-track strategic and security-related projects, especially last-mile connectivity and development of border villages. It proposes that forest